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“The People” *Imagined, Felt, and Experienced* by Populist Supporters: A Cross-National and Cross-Ideological Approach

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ABSTRACT

“The people” is a central concept in populism, yet it remains unclear how those who identify with this community interpret it. Drawing on social identity theory and fandom studies, this study examines how populist supporters identify with “the people.” Using a comparative analysis of right- and left-wing populist supporters in the United States and Spain, the study analyzes 33 in-depth interviews (between April and October 2021) and 6,000 online community interactions (between September 2019 and January 2021). This approach captures both individual and collective interpretations while highlighting how media, especially digital platforms, shape imagined communities by fostering shared identities and emotions and encouraging social and political engagement. Findings reveal three interconnected dimensions of identification with “the people”: the imagined, the felt, and the experienced. Supporters’ positive view of “the people” as hard-working and guided by common sense evokes strong emotions – such as in-group love, connected to their self-concept – validated through meaningful social experiences online and offline. This study emphasizes the central role of social motivation in populist engagement and highlights the need for further cross-national, cross-ideological research to deepen scholarly understanding of populism.

KEYWORDS

Populism; supporters; social identity theory; fan studies; qualitative methods

The rise of what Mudde (2004) called the “populist zeitgeist” highlights the jump of populist discourse into mainstream politics worldwide, characterized by its division of society into “the pure people” and “the corrupt elites” (Mudde, 2004, p. 543). While the idea of “the people” is central to populism, it is unclear what being part of this group means. As described by Mudde (2004): “the people of the populists are an ‘imagined community,’ much like the nation of the nationalists. At the same time, the notion of the heartland does not overcome the main problem of the people, its vagueness. It is as unclear, and has consequently been used differently from populist to populist, even within one country” (p. 546). What we do know is that media play a crucial role in creating and shaping imagined communities by reflecting a shared past, present, and fate (Anderson, 2006; Juarez Miro, 2019). Digital media have expanded this role, creating spaces for shared practices and values (Baym, 2000; Jenkins, 1992) and facilitating political engagement, mobilization, and participation (Beyer, 2014).

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This study examines how populist supporters use diverse media to identify with their imagined community of “the people,” negotiate its meanings, and respond to news and political messages. It does so through a comparative analysis of the United States and Spain, both countries where populist movements have emerged in recent years across the ideological spectrum – right-wing leaders like Donald Trump in the U.S. and Santiago Abascal in Spain, and left-wing figures such as Bernie Sanders and Pablo Iglesias. This cross-national and cross-ideological approach aims to provide deeper insights into populist phenomena, transcending their contextual variations (Mudde & Rovira Kaltwasser, 2018).

At a time when populist communication is increasingly significant, this study focuses on the perspectives of “the people,” rhetorically constructed and mobilized by populism. Using a theoretical framework informed by social identity theory and fan studies, it specifically examines how populist supporters identify with “the people.” This question is addressed through 33 in-depth interviews with populist supporters and an analysis of 6,000 posts and responses in their most frequented virtual communities. Findings reveal three interconnected dimensions of identification with “the people”: the imagined, the felt, and the experienced. Populist supporters *imagined* “the people” in overwhelmingly positive terms – linking them to hard work and a common-sense majority – which made them *feel* strong emotions – such as love for the in-group, connected to their self-concept – further reinforced through fulfilling social *experiences* with fellow members both online and offline.

“The People” in Populism

Populism has been conceptualized as an ideology (Mudde, 2004), a type of rhetoric (Bonikowski & Gidron, 2016), a political style (Moffitt, 2016), a discourse (Laclau, 2005), a frame (Aslanidis, 2016), a message characteristic (Rooduijn et al., 2014), and a regime (Caramani, 2017), with all perspectives emphasizing the opposition between a supposedly homogeneous and virtuous people and an equally homogeneous and corrupt elite. This opposition highlights three core subcomponents of populism: people-centrism, anti-elitism, and anti-pluralism (e.g., Castanho Silva et al., 2020). In this article, populism is conceptualized as a form of communication where messages express a worldview structured around these subcomponents (Mudde, 2004; Rooduijn et al., 2012), thereby identifying citizens who endorse these ideas as populist supporters. While “the people” is central to populism, its indefiniteness allows for flexible, context and ideologically dependent meanings, enhancing the adaptability and success of populist rhetoric (Laclau, 2005; Mudde, 2004; Mudde and Rovira Kaltwasser, 2018). Emotion plays a key role here, as populism appeals focus on a supposedly homogeneous group of “the people’s” needs and goals, which citizens negotiate, accept, or reject (Canovan, 1984, 2002; Ostiguy & Moffitt, 2020; Spruyt et al., 2016).

Despite this ambiguity, scholars of populism have identified several key conceptualizations of “the people” in elite political discourse: a cultural notion (“the people” as a nation, associated with right-wing populism), an economic notion (“the people” as an underprivileged class, linked to left-wing populism), a political notion (“the people” as sovereign, present in both right- and left-wing populism), and a broader, everyday use (Canovan, 1984; Mény & Surel, 2000). Elites, both populist and non-populist, often understand “the people” as a stand-in for public opinion, a perception shaped by traditional media and used discursively to foster a more direct, personalized, and authentic style of political

communication (Strikovic et al., 2020). However, across historical contexts and ideologies, populist movements hinge on a moralized and anti-pluralist idea of “the people” as a unified and morally pure entity that only the populist leader can authentically represent, implying that those who do not support the leader may not truly belong to “the people” at all (Müller, 2016). Additionally, while politicians in general engage in people-centric discourse to mobilize their constituencies, populist leaders tend to display a distinct pattern: a more frequent and intense focus on “the people,” combined with strong anti-elitism, a hallmark of populism across the ideological spectrum (Jagers & Walgrave, 2007; Zulianello et al., 2018).

Furthermore, extensive research on the reception side of populism suggests that perceived status loss and government unresponsiveness – often amplified by media coverage of economic crises and corruption (Mudde, 2004) – as well as reactions to cultural pluralism and immigration marked by feelings of anomie and identity loss (Ivarsflaten, 2008; Norris & Inglehart, 2019) strengthen support for populism (Hawkins et al., 2017; Spruyt et al., 2016). At the individual level, studies on populist attitudes have identified core ideas such as identification with “the people,” developed attitude scales to measure them (e.g., Akkerman et al., 2014), and highlighted politically mobilizing emotions – most notably anger – that drive these attitudes (Rico et al., 2017). This work has been valuable for measuring the extent to which people identify with “the people” and how such identification shapes support for populism. However, no single attitudinal predictor has been established, and concerns about validity and cross-national applicability remain (Castanho Silva et al., 2020; Rooduijn, 2018).

While quantitative approaches are essential for assessing the extent to which people identify with “the people,” qualitative inquiries add a crucial dimension by unearthing how those who do so conceptualize this group. In that vein, research has shown how populist supporters use social media to collectively interpret populist messages and discursively construct “the people,” often portraying it as threatened by elites and certain social groups they exclude (e.g., Juarez Miro, 2021; Hameleers, 2019). This work underscores the importance of considering populist supporters as media users and audience communities to understand how they negotiate meanings of belonging in “the people.” Building on this, the present study explores how populist supporters identify with “the people.” Its cross-ideological and cross-national scope, combined with its methodological focus on supporters’ voices, integrating discourse analysis in online communities with interviews, makes it especially well-suited to deepen this understanding and help address validity and cross-national applicability challenges in research on populist attitudes.

From Communication to Community

To understand how populist supporters identify with “the people,” it is crucial to examine how they communicate their belonging, as communication is central to forming communities by articulating and affirming shared beliefs and values (Anderson, 2006; Carey, 1992). As populist communication frames society around in-groups and out-groups, contrasting “the people” with elites, social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1979) offers a valuable framework. Applied to populism, social identity theory helps explain how identity frames activate populist attitudes and persuade voters (Bos et al., 2020; Hameleers et al., 2021), and are associated with false consensus effects, hostile media perceptions (Schulz et al., 2020), as

well as negative social identities (Spruyt et al., 2016). Two cognitive processes are especially relevant: self-categorization, through which individuals recognize and emotionally bond with a group – within populism, identifying as part of “the people” – and social comparison, through which they evaluate their group against others to achieve positive distinctiveness, with “the people” framed as possessing positive traits (Mudde, 2004; Tajfel, 1972; Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Social identity theory thus offers a lens for examining how populist supporters understand their connection to “the people.”

Additionally, to examine how “the people” develops as an affective community, this study draws on fan studies to explore populist supporters’ emotional engagement with a cultural object, namely populism, as well as one another (Hills, 2002). Such engagement unfolds across five communicative dimensions that fulfill needs for belonging and self-expression, sustaining community participation: deep involvement, collective meaning-making, the creation and sharing of cultural products, advocacy, and participation in alternative social communities (Hobson, 1989; Horton & Wohl, 1956; Jenkins, 1992). Within community interactions, shared practices and interpretations are crucial to maintaining these communities (Baym, 2000). Fandom thus offers a valuable lens to examine community-building and meaning-making among populist supporters (Juarez Miro, 2021), especially considering that leisure-driven participation, despite its playful appearance, can reflect deep political commitment (Krupnikov & Ryan, 2022; Miller, 2020; Winter, 2020).

A framework combining fan studies and social identity theory offers useful conceptual tools for examining how populist supporters understand populism, identify with “the people,” and express belonging to this imagined community. Both perspectives emphasize that shared meanings and emotions sustain communities, with communication at their core. It is through communication, particularly political discussion, that individuals interpret events, recognize group dynamics, and clarify not only where they stand but with whom (Cramer, 2004; Gamson, 1992; Price, 1989). Furthermore, in today’s hybrid media system, platform affordances enable enhanced political discussion (Chadwick, 2017).

In that sense, within online communities, varying levels of anonymity, regulation, and group size shape political discussion in ways that foster both social ties and mobilization (Beyer, 2014). Through these mediated interactions, members can signal belonging via shared symbols and prototypical behaviors, and distinguish themselves from out-groups (Jenkins, 1992; Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Digital media’s affordances such as interactivity, asynchronicity, demassification, and hypertextuality allow populist supporters to discuss politics, navigate conversations, and create or circulate user-generated content with ease (Juarez Miro, 2021; Ruggiero, 2000). In this way, populist supporters can use digital media to shape their identity as members of “the people,” defining themselves positively in opposition to negatively characterized out-groups, and doing so independently of populist elites (Hameleers, 2019). Examining how supporters construct, interpret, and communicate this identity offers important insights for a deeper understanding of populism.

Methodology

Given the limited knowledge of how populist supporters imagine “the people,” this study adopted a comparative case study approach to gain in-depth insights across national and ideological contexts. Comparative studies are essential to understanding populism beyond specific settings (Mudde & Rovira Kaltwasser, 2018). While research has pursued

comparative approaches (e.g., Aytaç & Öniş, 2014; Ivaldi et al., 2017; Mudde & Rovira Kaltwasser, 2013; Weyland, 1999), few studies have compared countries and ideologically distinct forms of populism simultaneously. This is partly because such comparisons often appear in edited volumes or special issues rather than integrated studies (e.g., Ionescu & Gellner, 1969; Rovira Kaltwasser & Taggart, 2016). This study examined the U.S. and Spain – contrasting in political culture but similar in hosting successful right- and left-wing populist movements – making them well-suited for a most-different case design (Gerring, 2007). While accounting for differences, it focused on core similarities, as shared understandings of “the people” are central to populism.

A Cross-National and Cross-Ideological Comparison: United States and Spain

Although an exhaustive review of the U.S. and Spanish media and political systems is beyond this study’s scope,¹ several considerations are relevant. The U.S. has a broad press market, low political parallelism, professionalized journalism, and limited state involvement, whereas Spain shows opposite traits (Brüggemann et al., 2014; Hallin & Mancini, 2004). These differences reflect distinct political histories: liberal republicanism in the U.S. fostered press freedom and resistance to state control (Starr, 2004), whereas Spain’s long dictatorship enabled greater state influence and hindered journalistic professionalization (Papatheodorou & Machin, 2003). Still, both countries offer strong grounds for cross-ideological comparison, each hosting right- and left-wing populist forces. In the U.S., Donald Trump and Bernie Sanders exemplify right- and left-wing populism (Hawkins & Rovira Kaltwasser, 2018), while in Spain, Santiago Abascal and Pablo Iglesias play parallel roles (Vampa, 2020).

Trump’s rise was shaped by the Obama presidency and Black Lives Matter protests, which some perceived as threats to established racial hierarchies (Hochschild, 2016; Norris & Inglehart, 2019). In Spain, Abascal’s ascent was driven by reactions to the Catalan pro-independence movement, widely framed as a major threat to national unity (Pardos-Prado, 2020). Meanwhile, the platforms of Sanders and Iglesias gained momentum following the 2008 Great Recession, which intensified critiques of inequality and elite corruption. For Sanders supporters, this fueled support for democratic socialism, particularly in education and healthcare, while in Spain it mobilized opposition to systemic corruption, exemplified by scandals such as the Gürtel case (Tamames, 2020).

To examine how populist supporters’ identification with “the people” is shaped by intersecting social identities, national histories, and recent political events (Coles & Lane, 2023; Kreiss et al., 2017), this study employed a qualitative design. In-depth phone and video interviews with respondents in the U.S. and Spain offered insight into their lived experiences and reflections. To complement these introspective accounts and mitigate social desirability bias, public interactions in online communities supporting Trump, Sanders, Abascal, and Iglesias were also analyzed. An inductive, iterative approach allowed findings to guide subsequent steps.

Interviews

To facilitate a space for populist supporters to share their perspectives (Legard et al., 2003), interviews were conducted between April and October 2021. Participants were recruited via a screener survey based on three criteria: (1) agreement with populist ideas

(Roccato et al., 2019); (2) positive attitudes about the relevant populist leaders; and (3) recent engagement with online political content.² Recruitment proved challenging, mainly due to the difficulty of reaching politically disenfranchised and academically skeptical populations (e.g., Blee, 2007). Thus, initial recruitment through Facebook ads was supplemented by third-party firms and snowball sampling. In all cases, consent was obtained through the screener survey. The study, including the consent process, recruitment methods, and participant compensation, was approved by the University of Minnesota's Institutional Review Board (STUDY00011155).

A total of 33 interviews were conducted, averaging 76 minutes (ranging 46–114 minutes), with nine Trump supporters, eight Sanders supporters, eight Abascal supporters, and eight Iglesias supporters.³ Interviews explored identification with “the people,” focusing on definitions and excluded groups (e.g., How is your ideal [country]? What are your beliefs and values? Which groups of people do you think could stand in the way of achieving the things you believe in?), interpretations of the populist message and related emotions (e.g., Could you define [politician]’s philosophy? How do you feel about other supporters?), online community experiences (e.g., How often do you talk or discuss things [there]? How would you characterize the other people [there]?), and motivations for participating (e.g., What are you looking for when you go [there]? What do you feel when you are [there]?).⁴ Interviews were conducted in participants’ native languages, English and Spanish.

Online Communities

Communication in online communities involves cultural and meaning-making exchanges reflecting shared beliefs, values, and customs (Kozinets, 2010). Thus, to examine populist supporters’ collective interpretations in natural settings, this study included a discourse analysis of online community interactions, unearthing shared practices, language, narratives, emotions, and personal fulfillment. Observation spanned from September 17, 2019, to January 7, 2021, covering periods when Trump and Iglesias were in office alongside major political events like the 2019 Spanish general election, U.S. Democratic primaries, and the January 6 Capitol break-in. This timeframe ensured ideological symmetry and captured politically significant moments likely to generate relevant discussion for the analysis.

Online communities were selected based on interviews and existing research. Interviewees primarily mentioned Facebook. Additionally, research identifies Reddit as a key platform for highly engaged Trump and Sanders supporters (Waller & Anderson, 2021), ForoCoches for Abascal supporters (Juarez Miro & Toff, 2022), and Instagram for Iglesias supporters (CIS-Centro de Investigaciones Sociológicas, 2019). Content was sampled using CrowdTangle for Facebook, Reddit, and Instagram, while public ForoCoches threads with “Abascal” in the title were automatically collected. Although Facebook and Reddit removed some Trump-related content due to policy violations (Wong, 2020), and deleted data was inaccessible via CrowdTangle (Fraser, 2021), supportive posts for all four leaders remained widespread. A random sample of 50 posts was selected from the Facebook pages, Facebook groups, Instagram pages, Reddit searches, and ForoCoches threads collected. The first 10 comments and their responses were manually collected to create a comprehensive yet manageable sample, prioritizing chronological order over engagement to avoid bias toward sensationalist content. In total, 6,000 comments and responses were analyzed (1,500 per case).⁵

Data Analysis

Data analysis involved three steps: (1) data immersion, (2) first-cycle coding, and (3) second-cycle coding (Saldaña, 2013; Tracy, 2013), all done manually. Analytical memos (Saldaña, 2013) guided reflections on data content and relationships among codes. For interviews, pseudonyms were used to protect participants' identities. For both interview and online community interactions, illustrative excerpts in Spanish were translated by the author, and language was only corrected when it prevented understanding.

Findings

In response to the research question, the analysis identified three interrelated dimensions of populist supporters' identification with "the people." The first, "the people" *imagined*, focuses on how supporters interpret elite discourse, understand the social identity of "the people," and perceive their membership through social categorization and comparison. The second, "the people" *felt*, refers to the formation of affective ties with the community and fellow members, drawing on concepts of positive distinctiveness and affective communities. The third, "the people" *experienced*, encompasses practices that signal membership and strengthen the community. Supporters' imaginations, feelings and experiences were intertwined with other social and political identities, grounded in each country's historical and political contexts (Coles & Lane, 2023; Kreiss et al., 2017).

"The People" Imagined

Populist supporters imagined "the people" as having positive attributes viewing these traits as essential for legitimate membership and seeing members as uniquely possessing them. This created an umbrella social identity that encompassed groups like the working class, the common-sense majority, and the nation. While these meanings were present in both interviews and online communities, interviews allowed for a deeper exploration of how supporters articulated and understood them.

The Working Class

Both right- and left-wing populist supporters emphasized hard work as a core value of "the people," reflecting an overlap with working-class identity in contrast to elites. These findings align with research identifying perceived deservingness and hard work as traits conferring moral worth on "the people" (Hochschild, 2016). Despite its traditional association with socialism, right-wing populists also embraced the working-class label. As Imanol, an Abascal supporter, explained: "The right is nowadays seen as 'you are conservative, you have money,' and that's not the case for me, I'm a normal worker." Among some right-wing supporters, the boundary between "the people" and the elites extended to groups perceived as not working hard, contributing equally, or facing similar struggles. Black Americans in the U.S. and immigrants in both countries were portrayed as unfair welfare beneficiaries, a view stemming from perceived relative deprivation (Gest, 2016; Hochschild, 2016; Spruyt et al., 2016). This narrative excluded them from the working class and, by extension, from "the people," casting them instead as enemies (Müller, 2016).

Left-wing populists in both countries, meanwhile, argued that working-class support for the right stemmed from elite manipulation. As Andrea, an Iglesias supporter, put it: “I don’t know if we are masochistic or stupid, because [...] most of us here are working people, medium-lower class. [Yet] they hit your pocket, and you still clap for them.” This view cast “the people” as a morally worthy yet easily misled working class, shedding light on both the ideological shift among working class supporters and the reciprocal dynamics of exclusion.

The Nation

Findings suggest an alignment between “the people” and the nation, with right- and left-wing populist supporters defining “the people” as “true” Americans and Spaniards. Historical narratives, which participants articulated in ways that reflected racial and ethnic identities and views on immigration, shaped these definitions (Anderson, 2006). Trump supporters prominently referenced the Founding Fathers and their ideals. As Elizabeth explained: “That document that gave us our freedoms – to see that get trampled on is heart-breaking because it was my family’s blood, sweat, and tears that went into forming this country [...], so that they wouldn’t live under constant persecution.” This vision of “the people” centered on continuity with the nation’s founders, implicitly aligning “the people” with those historically positioned as white, male, and socioeconomically privileged. In contrast, Sanders supporters embraced the “melting pot” metaphor, emphasizing diversity – including racial, ethnic, and citizenship status – as a definitional feature of both the American nation and “the people.” As, Amelia, a Sanders supporter, explained in an interview: “America is about the melting pot, everybody contributing, making a new thing, it’s not about, ‘Oh, we’re white and we’re going to keep these stupid flags and everything else.’”

Similarly, in Spain, national history also shaped how populist supporters understood “the people.” As in the U.S., narratives linked national identity to personal and family histories, reinforcing the connection between “the people,” the nation, and the self. Spanish populists often expressed discomfort with regional cultural and linguistic differences, promoting a vision of “the people” as a homogeneous national group that downplayed Spain’s regional identities. References to the Civil War (e.g., identifying with a faction), Franco’s dictatorship, and the transition to democracy appeared more frequently in interviews than in online communities. Explicit Franco support, however, surfaced only in Abascal supporters’ online communities, likely due to perceived acceptance within the group.

The Common-Sense Majority

Populist supporters saw themselves as representing their country’s majority, believing that shared struggles made supporting populism common sense. While acknowledging that not all citizens agreed politically, they still expressed perceived consensus among “the people.” This was reflected in their use of “us” and “them” language to define in-groups and out-groups (Tajfel & Turner, 1979), which helped them view themselves as sharing goals, history, and enemies – key to imagining communities (Anderson, 2006). This language, which fostered unity by minimizing individual differences, appeared in interviews and online communities. For instance, in an interview, Thea used “we” to refer to herself and fellow Sanders supporters as she expressed disappointment over the senator’s 2020 campaign withdrawal: “Now we’re in that lull where none of the candidates really have the same appeal.”

In online communities, supporters used similar language and identity cues to signal belonging to “the people” and promote shared assumptions, such as the idea that supporting their preferred leader was common sense. For example, a post in the Facebook group “USA for Trump” stated, “We stand with Trump 100%.” The use of “we” invoked other imagined members of “the people,” implying unanimous support for Trump within the community and signaling that such support was a shared norm (Jenkins, 1992; Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Specific language, practices, and assumptions helped supporters recognize one another within the online community and reinforced their sense of collective identity (Baym, 2000).

In summary, while interpretations of the working class and national identity varied by ideology, their symbolic link to “the people” remained central to how populist supporters identified with the imagined community. This study builds on literature identifying elite-level interpretations of “the people” as either a nation (right-wing populism) or an underprivileged class (left-wing populism) (Canovan, 1984; Mény & Surel, 2000) by examining how supporters themselves construct its meaning. Consistent with research showing that populist rhetoric assigns positive qualities to “the people” (Mudde, 2004), supporters described themselves as a working-class, culturally unified majority guided by common sense. They identified with “the people” as an umbrella identity merging cultural and economic dimensions in ways that appeared natural and politically legitimate. These findings extend scholarship emphasizing populism’s antipluralist vision of “the people” (Müller, 2016) by showing how supporters internalize and reproduce this identity through narrative meaning-making, incorporating and excluding other political and social identities based on ideology, historical context, and the specific dimension of “the people” invoked. Beyond enabling elites to tap into issues across ideological lines, this matters because combining multiple social identities under an umbrella identity can deepen attachment and loyalty to that identity (Mason & Wronski, 2018).

“The People” Felt

Populist supporters’ identification with “the people” was marked by intense emotions, including love for fellow supporters and leaders, as well as anger or fear toward perceived outsiders such as elites and political opponents. This dynamic was especially visible in online communities, where emotions signaled group norms and desirable practices (Baym, 2000). Interviews provided insight into how supporters experienced and interpreted these emotions.

Love for “The People.”

Populist supporters expressed strong affection for fellow members of “the people,” turning to social media to connect with them. Online communities reinforced their identification with “the people” through visible in-group loyalty and out-group rejection, a feature of affective polarization (Mason, 2018). For example, a post in the Facebook group “Club de Fans Santiago Abascal” contrasted a photo of Spanish politicians with one of Abascal at a rally surrounded by Spanish flags, captioned “them?” or “us?” Replies included: “Us (3 green hearts),” “4 green hearts,” “Us,” “Vox (Spanish flag) Spain.” These exchanges illustrate collective meaning-making that strengthens affective political ties (Barnes, 2022). In-group symbolic markers such as profile pictures, emojis, and party colors – like national

flags for Abascal and Trump supporters or green and purple hearts for Abascal and Iglesias supporters – further signaled belonging to “the people.” Positive peer feedback strengthened these bonds (Baym, 2000), underscoring this identity’s role in supporters’ online personas.

In interviews, populist supporters described forming or joining tight-knit online communities with fellow members of “the people” as emotionally rewarding, reflecting the affective bonds rooted in social connection found in fan cultures (Hills, 2002). As Juana, an Iglesias supporter, explained: “In my group of friends, I have right-wing people, and I won’t stop thinking of them as friends because of that. But on Facebook, I get to pick and choose. [...] You feel good commenting with like-minded people, because you share the same ideas, even if your views differ, you feel comfortable, happy, and can stay there a bit longer.”

Love for the Leader

Populist supporters perceived their leaders as unfairly targeted by elites and the media, viewing their resilience as proof of love for “the people.” This affection was reciprocated through admiration and devotion, especially online. For instance, on the subreddit “r/AskTrumpSupporters,” a Trump supporter wrote: “If I got the chance to sit down have dinner and talk about his life and knowledge, I feel it would be one of the greatest honors.” Similarly, an Abascal supporter addressed him with familiarity on his official Facebook page: “Santi, I am so sorry that I couldn’t attend [the rally] because of my husband’s health. We were both looking forward to going to such an important meeting.” A Sanders supporter playfully posted on Facebook: “I know it’s weird because I think of Bernie as like Yoda but. . .he was kind of hot in ‘93. I have a thing for gray hair. Sorry.” These affective expressions reflect attachment to political ideals and leaders’ personalities, appearance, and symbolic role within the imagined community. This is important, as leaders’ fandomization and perceived membership in the affective community around “the people” can enhance political engagement and participation (Juarez Miro, 2021; McMillin, 2020).

In interviews, populist supporters expanded on the idea that their leaders were exceptional because they used power to advocate for them (Norris & Inglehart, 2019). While opposing other elites, supporters saw their leaders as relatable and part of their communities. Carlos, an Iglesias supporter, reflected this sentiment: “I remember that European election when the elderly and people of all ages showed up and looked for [Iglesias’] ballot. It was moving, that moment was moving, and he was one of us.” These accounts conveyed a belief that leaders understood their struggles and truly cared, reinforcing trust that they sought office to represent and fulfill “the people’s” will.

Anger and Fear

Populist supporters expressed intense anger toward elites and other groups perceived as outside “the people,” particularly in online communities. Given the timing of the fieldwork – after George Floyd’s murder in 2020 and the subsequent global protests, and the 2019 trial and imprisonment of Catalan pro-independence leaders, in which Vox played a prominent role (Pardos-Prado, 2020) – Black Lives Matter and Catalan pro-independence leaders, but also perceived supporters, became salient targets for Trump and Abascal supporters. In contrast, Sanders and Iglesias supporters directed their anger toward the wealthy and specific political elites. A post on the Facebook group “Our Progressive Revolution – Bernie Sanders in the 117th US Congress” reflects this: “I have anger I don’t even know

what to do with. . . anger at the DNC, Trump, Biden and everyone who rigged this against the American people.” Such emotions shaped the tone of these spaces, where vitriolic, politically incorrect language was common. In interviews, participants explained that they expressed emotions this way because they saw these communities as composed of fellow members of “the people,” and believed others shared them, suggesting a search for acceptance and validation.

While anger dominated online spaces, fear was more prominent in interviews. Supporters described intense anxiety over their ideological opponents’ success, reflecting perceived intergroup conflict (Mason, 2018). Their leaders’ victories were seen as essential, with rival rule imagined in dystopian terms. Trump and Abascal supporters warned of Venezuela and communism, while Sanders and Iglesias supporters invoked Nazi Germany, Francoist Spain, fascism, and slavery. Savannah, a Trump supporter, voiced these fears with vivid emotion during her interview: “I’ve attended protests in Washington DC, in Boston. [. . .] This is me fighting for my country because I feel . . . Sorry, I’m getting upset. I feel like we’re losing America and the things we were founded on, and I’m worried. I have a little niece, she’s five. I don’t want her to grow up in a country where she’s eating out of a garbage can like in Venezuela and people suffering under communist rule.”

In summary, supporters’ identification with “the people” involved deep love for fellow members, resembling Anderson’s (2006) imagined communities. They also expressed personal appreciation for the leaders, reinforced through parasocial bonds via digital media. Intense anger and fear toward opponents, including political figures and members of excluded social groups such as racial and regional identities, suggest affective polarization tied to this identity (Mason, 2018). These findings underscore the emotional dimension of populism as a driver of political engagement, building on work showing that populism can alleviate feelings of discontent and vulnerability by sustaining a positive social identity (Hochschild, 2016; Spruyt et al., 2016). Furthermore, while elite populist communication often uses emotional, personalized terms contrasting “the people” with elites (Ostiguy & Moffitt, 2020; Strikovic et al., 2020), this study shows that supporters reflect and may amplify this framing in everyday discourse, normalizing intense emotional and political engagement.

“The People” Experienced

Populist supporters’ interpretations and emotions about “the people” were reinforced through engagement with others they perceived as fellow members – recognizing one another, sharing messages, defending beliefs, and staying politically informed. These interactions were visible in online communities but also occurred offline. Interviews clarified how such engagement deepened supporters’ sense of belonging and purpose, contributing to their political mobilization.

Sense of Belonging

Populist supporters’ narratives reflected a deep sense of connection and mutual understanding with fellow members of “the people.” This sense of belonging was fostered through meaningful interactions in online communities, consistent with the idea that social connection is central to affective communities (Jenkins, 1992). For example, an Iglesias supporter commented on the Facebook page “Pablo Iglesias

Presidente del Gobierno 2018,” expressing a strong bond with another user that transcended words: “I feel exactly the same. Words are not needed . . .”. Notably, these interactions often occurred among strangers united by support for their populist leader.

While connecting with fellow members of “the people” was important across cases, right-wing populists were especially vocal in interviews about the emotional reward of finding affirmation in these communities amid perceived political persecution. In that sense, describing his experience connecting online with perceived fellow members of “the people,” Oscar, an Abascal supporter, said: “‘They share my opinion, I am not weird, then.’ That’s what I think. ‘More people see it this way,’ it makes me feel satisfied.”

Experiences of belonging extended offline through casual gatherings, public recognition via political symbols, and participation in rallies, all reinforcing their social identity. In interviews, populist supporters described these moments as deeply enjoyable and validating. Reflecting this, Andrew, a Sanders supporter, described feeling a deeper, more meaningful connection with fellow supporters than with long-time friends who held opposing views: “People I grew up with who are so far off politically, I don’t spend as much time with as with a like-minded person. They’re not coming to my house, while the other guy can come and not even knock, just come in.”

Sense of Purpose

Membership in “the people” also gave supporters a sense of purpose. For right-wing populists, this was closely tied to national pride, both in interviews and online exchanges. This is illustrated in an interview with Sabina, a Trump supporter, who made the connection explicitly: “Oh, I just . . . Pride. I have just so much pride for [Trump] and how he likes America, and he’s tried to help us.” Similarly, in online communities, advancing the goals of “the people” was closely tied to expressions of patriotic pride. This connects back to the imagined national dimension of “the people” invoked by populist supporters, envisioned as a homogeneous group rooted in shared bellicose myths and selective historical narratives that reaffirmed dominant social identities. For example, a post on Abascal’s official Facebook page did so through historical imagery: “I’ll give my vote and my blood to defend Spain if it’s necessary. I am thankful for my patria [homeland], where our ancestors grew up and fought to give us an extraordinary life.”

In contrast, Sanders and Iglesias supporters focused more on hope and the future than on historical narratives, both in interviews and online communities. Underlying these expressions, however, was also an assumed consensus on what progress entails and the values that should guide society. In her interview, Belen, an Iglesias supporter, spoke directly about hope: “I feel that at least a percentage of the population thinks like me, and that being progressive, I am a bit more hopeful about this country, although sometimes I have my doubts.” This future-centered vision was echoed online, where supporters advocated radical change tied to ideals like equality, human rights, and social justice. As one Sanders supporter on the “r/politics” subreddit wrote: “I don’t want more of the status quo, I want real progressive change.”

Increased Mobilization

An enhanced sense of belonging and purpose translated into greater political mobilization, as seen in both interviews and online communities. In an interview, Julie recalled becoming

more politically engaged after aligning with Trump: “I’ll be honest with you. Years ago, I was never this into politics until Trump started to put in his ticket. I learned so much more about politics since then. I started paying attention.” Similar experiences of increased mobilization upon identification with “the people” were shared online, reflecting the assumption that these were widely understood. As one Abascal supporter posted on his official Facebook page: “I never cared about politics. I didn’t even vote many times because no one represented me and, since last year, I have been thinking you might make it. Don’t ever change.”

These expressions reflect populism’s emphasis on the will of “the people” (Mudde, 2004), illustrating how identification with “the people” and perceived widespread support increased supporters’ sense of efficacy. This empowered supporters to channel political dissatisfaction into greater interest and participation. One Iglesias supporter, for example, expressed this sense of agency on the politician’s official Facebook page: “It’s time to turn around history with a great change. The new century is that of regeneration. Yes, we can.” This belief in their own political impact appeared to be a powerful source of motivation.

In summary, populist supporters’ social interactions with fellow members of “the people” enhanced their sense of belonging, purpose, and political motivation. They deeply valued connecting with like-minded individuals, a process facilitated by digital technology that fulfills key social needs and fosters continued engagement (Hobson, 1989; Horton & Wohl, 1956). These findings highlight the social dimension of identification with “the people.” Feeling part of something larger provided political motivation and a renewed sense of existential and moral purpose. Supporters emphasized that social experiences were validating, deeply rewarding, and a central driver of their support for populism. Thus, this study suggests that identifying with “the people” as a social identity can enhance political efficacy and encourage participation, including via rallies, social media activism, and voting.

Conclusion

This study offers a cross-national and cross-ideological exploration of how populist supporters identify with “the people,” uncovering three interrelated dimensions of this identification: the imagined, the felt, and the experienced. By examining these dimensions through introspective narratives and collective accounts, the study contributes to research in populist communication by highlighting its cognitive, emotional, and social aspects. Imagining themselves as part of a community associated with overwhelmingly positive traits evoked strong positive emotions among populist supporters, which were further amplified and validated through social interactions with fellow supporters both online and offline.

Supporters’ imagined community of “the people” was shaped by intersecting identities (racial, ethnic, class, gender, national, regional), which served as lenses for interpreting political life and their sense of belonging (Coles & Lane, 2023; Kreiss et al., 2017). Findings show how supporters discursively drew moral boundaries by invoking historical myths that reified belonging and exclusion (Anderson, 2006). Trump and Abascal supporters imagined “the people,” through perceived status loss relative to marginalized groups (Gest, 2016; Hochschild, 2016; Norris & Inglehart, 2019), while Sanders and Iglesias supporters imagined a diverse, economically deprived “people” opposed to elites like the “billionaire class” or “la casta” (Stauffer, 2020; Tamames, 2020). Still, across cases, supporters framed “the

people” as unified, despite the diversity of identities included and excluded from the imagined community. Importantly, implicit inclusion or exclusion enabled the use of coded language and dog whistles, allowing some supporters to express exclusionary, anti-democratic ideas while maintaining plausible deniability.

A key contribution of this study is its analysis of the emotional and social dimensions through which populist supporters identify with “the people.” Emotionally, shared feelings of love for fellow members and through parasocial relationships with leaders akin to those found in fandoms helped bind the community, reinforce their identity, and strengthen their self-concept. While anger toward perceived enemies has been shown to mobilize populist supporters (Hochschild, 2016; Rico et al., 2017), this study also highlights fear as a driver. Above all, the findings emphasize that publicly expressed emotion can serve a performative function, signaling membership in “the people” and helping supporters connect with one another. Socially, engaging with fellow supporters was experienced as deeply enjoyable and meaningful, fostering belonging, validation, and shared purpose. This highlights a central role of social motivation in sustaining political participation in populist movements.

While this study advances understanding of populism by exploring how supporters identify with “the people,” it has several limitations. First, although it captured perceptions, emotions, and gratifications, it did not assess their intensity or frequency. Future research could quantify these dimensions, compare them with non-populist groups, and examine links to political participation. Second, interview responses may have been shaped by question phrasing, self-selection, or social desirability bias, though triangulation with online posts helped mitigate these effects. Third, platform differences influenced mobilization dynamics (Beyer, 2014): Reddit and ForoChoches offered greater anonymity, while Instagram enabled more direct interaction under stricter regulation. Nonetheless, community cohesion and shared meaning-making were consistent across platforms, likely due to ideological alignment. Including Facebook pages and groups across the four cases also helped reduce platform-specific effects. Despite these limitations, the study highlights the value of a multi-dimensional lens on populism, where political preferences and emotions are intertwined with social gratification. Additionally, a key strength of this study lies in its comparative design, which revealed consistent characteristics of populism across different contexts. This underscores the need for further comparative research to understand populism’s defining characteristics.

Notes

1. See Appendix A in the Supplementary Information file for relevant context on the social, political, economic, and media histories of the United States and Spain that help situate the findings of this study.
2. See Appendix B in the Supplementary Information file for more details on the screener survey employed.
3. See Appendix C in the Supplementary Information file for more details on the sample’s demographic distribution.
4. See Appendix D in the Supplementary Information file for more details on the semi-structured interview protocol.
5. See Appendix E in the Supplementary Information file for more details on the dataset.

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Data Availability Statement

The interview data underlying this article cannot be shared publicly to protect the privacy of individuals who participated in the study. Moreover, its sensitive nature, including potentially identifying information as well as information about social and political behaviors supports this decision. The social media data, given its public nature, can be found in the Supplementary File and was stored in a repository to be shared for scientific purposes.

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